D'Artagnan tried to recall his remembrances. He had gone to the rendezvous, had encountered there the adversary indicated, whose name he had never known, had given him a pretty sword-stroke on the arm, then had gone toward Aramis, who at the same time came to meet him, having already finished his affair. 'It is over,' Aramis had said. 'I think I have killed the insolent fellow. But, dear friend, if you ever need me you know that I am entirely devoted to you.' Thereupon Aramis had given him a clasp of the hand and had disappeared under the arcades.

So, then, he no more knew where Aramis was than where Athos and Porthos were, and the affair was becoming a matter of great perplexity, when he fancied he heard a pane of glass break in his room window. He thought directly of his bag and rushed from the inner room where he was sleeping. He was not mistaken; as he entered his bedroom a man was getting in by the window.

'Ah! you scoundrel!' cried D'Artagnan, taking the man for a thief and seizing his sword.

'Sir!' cried the man, 'in the name of Heaven put your sword back into the sheath and don't kill me unheard. I'm no thief, but an honest citizen, well off in the world, with a house of my own. My name is—ah! but surely you are Monsieur d'Artagnan?'

'And thou—Planchet!' cried the lieutenant.

'At your service, sir,' said Planchet, overwhelmed with joy; 'if I were still capable of serving you.'

'Perhaps so,' replied D'Artagnan. 'But why the devil dost thou run about the tops of houses at seven o'clock of the morning in the month of January?'

'Sir,' said Planchet, 'you must know; but, perhaps you ought not to know— '

'Tell us what,' returned D'Artagnan, 'but first put a napkin against the window and draw the curtains.'

'Sir,' said the prudent Planchet, 'in the first place, are you on good terms with Monsieur de Rochefort?'

'Perfectly; one of my dearest friends.'

'Ah! so much the better!'

'But what has De Rochefort to do with this manner you have of invading my room?'

'Ah, sir! I must first tell you that Monsieur de Rochefort is— '

Planchet hesitated.

'Egad, I know where he is,' said D'Artagnan. 'He's in the Bastille.'

'That is to say, he was there,' replied Planchet. 'But in returning thither last night, when fortunately you did not accompany him, as his carriage was crossing the Rue de la Ferronnerie his guards insulted the people, who began to abuse them. The prisoner thought this a good opportunity for escape; he called out his name and cried for help. I was there. I heard the name of Rochefort. I remembered him well. I said in a loud voice that he was a prisoner, a friend of the Duc de Beaufort, who called for help. The people were infuriated; they stopped the horses and cut the escort to pieces, whilst I opened the doors of the carriage and Monsieur de Rochefort jumped out and soon was lost amongst the crowd. At this moment a patrol passed by. I was obliged to sound a retreat toward the Rue Tiquetonne; I was pursued and took refuge in the house next to this, where I have been concealed between two mattresses. This morning I ventured to run along the gutters and— '

'Well,' interrupted D'Artagnan, 'I am delighted that De Rochefort is free, but as for thee, if thou shouldst fall into the hands of the king's servants they will hang thee without mercy. Nevertheless, I promise thee thou shalt be hidden here, though I risk by concealing thee neither more nor less than my lieutenancy, if it was found out that I gave one rebel an asylum.'

'Ah! sir, you know well I would risk my life for you.'

'Thou mayst add that thou hast risked it, Planchet. I have not forgotten all I owe thee. Sit down there and eat in security. I see thee cast expressive glances at the remains of my supper.'

'Yes, sir; for all I've had since yesterday was a slice of bread and butter, with preserves on it. Although I don't despise sweet things in proper time and place, I found the supper rather light.'

'Poor fellow!' said D'Artagnan. 'Well, come; set to.'

'Ah, sir, you are going to save my life a second time!' cried Planchet.

And he seated himself at the table and ate as he did in the merry days of the Rue des Fossoyeurs, whilst D'Artagnan walked to and fro and thought how he could make use of Planchet under present circumstances. While he turned this over in his mind Planchet did his best to make up for lost

time at table. At last he uttered a sigh of satisfaction and paused, as if he had partially appeased his hunger.

'Come,' said D'Artagnan, who thought that it was now a convenient time to begin his interrogations, 'dost thou know where Athos is?'

'No, sir,' replied Planchet.

'The devil thou dost not! Dost know where Porthos is?'

'No—not at all.'

'And Aramis?'

'Not in the least.'

'The devil! the devil! the devil!'

'But, sir,' said Planchet, with a look of shrewdness, 'I know where Bazin is.'

'Where is he?'

'At Notre Dame.'

'What has he to do at Notre Dame?'

'He is beadle.'

'Bazin beadle at Notre Dame! He must know where his master is!'

'Without a doubt he must.'

D'Artagnan thought for a moment, then took his sword and put on his cloak to go out.

'Sir,' said Planchet, in a mournful tone, 'do you abandon me thus to my fate? Think, if I am found out here, the people of the house, who have not seen me enter it, will take me for a thief.'

'True,' said D'Artagnan. 'Let's see. Canst thou speak any patois?'

'I can do something better than that, sir, I can speak Flemish.'

'Where the devil didst thou learn it?'

'In Artois, where I fought for years. Listen, sir. Goeden morgen, mynheer, eth ben begeeray le weeten the ge sond heets omstand.'

'Which means?'

'Good-day, sir! I am anxious to know the state of your health.'

'He calls that a language! But never mind, that will do capitally.'

D'Artagnan opened the door and called out to a waiter to desire Madeleine to come upstairs.

When the landlady made her appearance she expressed much astonishment at seeing Planchet.

convent he changed his name. Ah! if I were but learned in theology I should recollect what it was he used to dispute about with the curate of Montdidier and the superior of the Jesuits, when we were at Crèvecœur; I should know what doctrine he leans to and I should glean from that what saint he has adopted as his patron.

Well, suppose I go back to the cardinal and ask him for a passport into all the convents one can find, even into the nunneries? It would be a curious idea, and maybe I should find my friend under the name of Achilles. But, no! I should lose myself in the cardinal's opinion. Great people only thank you for doing the impossible; what's possible, they say, they can effect themselves, and they are right. But let us wait a little and reflect. I received a letter from him, the dear fellow, in which he even asked me for some small service, which, in fact, I rendered him. Yes, yes; but now what did I do with that letter?'

D'Artagnan thought a moment and then went to the wardrobe in which hung his old clothes. He looked for his doublet of the year 1648 and as he had orderly habits, he found it hanging on its nail. He felt in the pocket and drew from it a paper; it was the letter of Aramis:

> Monsieur D'Artagnan:
>
> You know that I have had a quarrel with a certain gentleman, who has given me an appointment for this evening in the Place Royale. As I am of the church, and the affair might injure me if I should share it with any other than a sure friend like you, I write to beg that you will serve me as second.
>
> You will enter by the Rue Neuve Sainte Catherine; under the second lamp on the right you will find your adversary. I shall be with mine under the third.
>
> Wholly yours,
>
> ARAMIS.

and calm, he was inspired with his clearest views of everything. It was long since he had any reason for his morning's inspiration, but he always slept all night long. At daybreak he awoke and took a turn around his room.

'In '43,' he said, 'just before the death of the late cardinal, I received a letter from Athos. Where was I then? Let me see. Oh! at the siege of Besançon I was in the trenches. He told me—let me think—what was it? That he was living on a small estate—but where? I was just reading the name of the place when the wind blew my letter away, I suppose to the Spaniards; there's no use in thinking any more about Athos. Let me see: with regard to Porthos, I received a letter from him, too. He invited me to a hunting party on his property in the month of September, 1646. Unluckily, as I was then in Bearn, on account of my father's death, the letter followed me there. I had left Bearn when it arrived and I never received it until the month of April, 1647; and as the invitation was for September, 1646, I couldn't accept it. Let me look for this letter; it must be with my title deeds.'

D'Artagnan opened an old casket which stood in a corner of the room, and which was full of parchments referring to an estate during a period of two hundred years lost to his family. He uttered an exclamation of delight, for the large handwriting of Porthos was discernible, and underneath some lines traced by his worthy spouse.

D'Artagnan eagerly searched for the heading of this letter; it was dated from the Château du Vallon.

Porthos had forgotten that any other address was necessary; in his pride he fancied that every one must know the Château du Vallon.

'Devil take the vain fellow,' said D'Artagnan. 'However, I had better find him out first, since he can't want money. Athos must have become an idiot by this time from drinking. Aramis must have worn himself to a shadow of his former self by constant genuflexion.'

He cast his eyes again on the letter. There was a postscript:

> I write by the same courier to our worthy friend Aramis in his convent.

'In his convent! What convent? There are about two hundred in Paris and three thousand in France; and then, perhaps, on entering the

'My dear landlady,' said D'Artagnan, 'I beg to introduce to you your brother, who is arrived from Flanders and whom I am going to take into my service.'

'My brother?'

'Wish your sister good-morning, Master Peter.'

'Wilkom, suster,' said Planchet.

'Goeden day, broder,' replied the astonished landlady.

'This is the case,' said D'Artagnan; 'this is your brother, Madeleine; you don't know him perhaps, but I know him; he has arrived from Amsterdam. You must dress him up during my absence. When I return, which will be in about an hour, you must offer him to me as a servant, and upon your recommendation, though he doesn't speak a word of French, I take him into my service. You understand?'

'That is to say, I guess your wishes, and that is all that's necessary,' said Madeleine.

'You are a precious creature, my pretty hostess, and I am much obliged to you.'

The next moment D'Artagnan was on his way to Notre Dame.

by my good looks, rode along to marry me. Then I should like to have three sons; I should make the first a nobleman, like Athos; the second a good soldier, like Porthos; the third an excellent abbé, like Aramis. Faith! that would be a far better life than I lead now; but Monsieur Mazarin is a mean wretch, who won't dispossess himself of his diamond in my favour.'

On entering the Rue Tiquetonne he heard a tremendous noise and found a dense crowd near the house.

'Oho!' said he, 'is the hotel on fire?' On approaching the hotel of the Roe he found, however, that it was in front of the next house the mob was collected. The people were shouting and running about with torches. By the light of one of these torches D'Artagnan perceived men in uniform.

He asked what was going on.

He was told that twenty citizens, headed by one man, had attacked a carriage which was escorted by a troop of the cardinal's bodyguard; but a reinforcement having come up, the assailants had been put to flight and the leader had taken refuge in the hotel next to his lodgings; the house was now being searched.

In his youth D'Artagnan had often headed the *bourgeoisie* against the military, but he was cured of all those hot-headed propensities; besides, he had the cardinal's hundred pistoles in his pocket, so he went into the hotel without a word. There he found Madeleine alarmed for his safety and anxious to tell him all the events of the evening, but he cut her short by ordering her to put his supper in his room and give him with it a bottle of good Burgundy.

He took his key and candle and went upstairs to his bedroom. He had been contented, for the convenience of the house, to lodge in the fourth story; and truth obliges us even to confess that his chamber was just above the gutter and below the roof. His first care on entering it was to lock up in an old bureau with a new lock his bag of money, and then as soon as supper was ready he sent away the waiter who brought it up and sat down to table.

Not to reflect on what had passed, as one might fancy. No, D'Artagnan considered that things are never well done when they are not reserved to their proper time. He was hungry; he supped, he went to bed. Neither was he one of those who think that the necessary silence of the night brings counsel with it. In the night he slept, but in the morning, refreshed

'There!' said D'Artagnan, 'what did I tell you? Fortunately, you won't be laid up more than a fortnight. Remain here and I will send you your clothes by the boy. Good-by! Oh, by the way, you'd better take lodging in the Rue Montorgueil at the Chat Qui Pelote. You will be well fed there, if the hostess remains the same. Adieu.'

Thereupon he returned in a lively mood to his room and sent to the Swiss the things that belonged to him. The boy found him sitting where D'Artagnan had left him, still overwhelmed by the coolness of his adversary.

The boy, the hostess, and all the house had the same regard for D'Artagnan that one would have for Hercules should he return to earth to repeat his twelve labours.

But when he was alone with the hostess he said: 'Now, pretty Madeleine, you know the difference between a Swiss and a gentleman. As for you, you have acted like a barmaid. So much the worse for you, for by such conduct you have lost my esteem and my patronage. I have driven away the Swiss to humiliate you, but I shall lodge here no longer. I will not sleep where I must scorn. Ho, there, boy! Have my valise carried to the Muid d'Amour, Rue des Bourdonnais. Adieu, madame.'

In saying these words D'Artagnan appeared at the same time majestic and grieved. The hostess threw herself at his feet, asked his pardon and held him back with a sweet violence. What more need be said? The spit turned, the stove roared, the pretty Madeleine wept; D'Artagnan felt himself invaded by hunger, cold and love. He pardoned, and having pardoned he remained.

And this explains how D'Artagnan had quarters in the Rue Tiquetonne, at the Hotel de la Chevrette.

D'Artagnan then returned home in thoughtful mood, finding a somewhat lively pleasure in carrying Mazarin's bag of money and thinking of that fine diamond which he had once called his own and which he had seen on the minister's finger that night.

'Should that diamond ever fall into my hands again,' he reflected, 'I would turn it at once into money; I would buy with the proceeds certain lands around my father's château, which is a pretty place, well enough, but with no land to it at all, except a garden about the size of the Cemetery des Innocents; and I should wait in all my glory till some rich heiress, attracted

Chapter VII

The Strange Effects a Half-Pistole May Have

D'Artagnan, as he crossed the Pont Neuf, congratulated himself on having found Planchet again, for at that time an intelligent servant was essential to him; nor was he sorry that through Planchet and the situation which he held in Rue des Lombards, a connection with the *bourgeoisie* might be commenced, at that critical period when that class were preparing to make war with the court party. It was like having a spy in the enemy's camp. In this frame of mind, grateful for the accidental meeting with Planchet, pleased with himself, D'Artagnan reached Notre Dame. He ran up the steps, entered the church, and addressing a verger who was sweeping the chapel, asked him if he knew Monsieur Bazin.

'Monsieur Bazin, the beadle?' said the verger. 'Yes. There he is, attending mass, in the chapel of the Virgin.'

D'Artagnan nearly jumped for joy; he had despaired of finding Bazin, but now, he thought, since he held one end of the thread he would be pretty sure to reach the other end.

He knelt down just opposite the chapel in order not to lose sight of his man; and as he had almost forgotten his prayers and had omitted to take a book with him, he made use of his time in gazing at Bazin.

Bazin wore his dress, it may be observed, with equal dignity and saintly propriety. It was not difficult to understand that he had gained the crown of his ambition and that the silver-mounted wand he brandished was in his eyes as honourable a distinction as the marshal's baton which Condé threw, or did not throw, into the enemy's line of battle at Fribourg. His

person had undergone a change, analogous to the change in his dress; his figure had grown rotund and, as it were, canonical. The striking points of his face were effaced; he had still a nose, but his cheeks, fattened out, each took a portion of it unto themselves; his chin had joined his throat; his eyes were swelled up with the puffiness of his cheeks; his hair, cut straight in holy guise, covered his forehead as far as his eyebrows.

The officiating priest was just finishing mass whilst D'Artagnan was looking at Bazin; he pronounced the words of the holy Sacrament and retired, giving the benediction, which was received by the kneeling communicants, to the astonishment of D'Artagnan, who recognised in the priest the coadjutor[1] himself, the famous Jean Francois Gondy, who at that time, having a presentiment of the part he was to play, was beginning to court popularity by almsgiving. It was to this end that he performed from time to time some of those early masses which the common people, generally, alone attended.

D'Artagnan knelt as well as the rest, received his share of the benediction and made the sign of the cross; but when Bazin passed in his turn, with his eyes raised to Heaven and walking, in all humility, the very last, D'Artagnan pulled him by the hem of his robe.

Bazin looked down and started, as if he had seen a serpent.

'Monsieur d'Artagnan!' he cried; '*Vade retro Satanas!*'

'So, my dear Bazin!' said the officer, laughing, 'this is the way you receive an old friend.'

'Sir,' replied Bazin, 'the true friends of a Christian are those who aid him in working out his salvation, not those who hinder him in doing so.'

'I don't understand you, Bazin; nor can I see how I can be a stumbling-block in the way of your salvation,' said D'Artagnan.

'You forget, sir, that you very nearly ruined forever that of my master; and that it was owing to you that he was very nearly being damned eternally for remaining a musketeer, whilst all the time his true vocation was the church.'

'My dear Bazin, you ought to perceive,' said D'Artagnan, 'from the place in which you find me, that I am greatly changed in everything. Age produces good sense, and, as I doubt not but that your master is on the

[1] A sacerdotal officer.

Feebleness obliged him to sit down

'Some one must go for help,' said a lad, who could not comprehend that this little man should make a stand against that other man, who was so large.

D'Artagnan, with a sudden accession of wrath, seized the lad by the ear and led him apart, with the injunction:

'Stay you where you are and don't you stir, or I will pull this ear off. As for you, illustrious descendant of William Tell, you will straightway get together your clothes which are in my room and which annoy me, and go out quickly to another lodging.'

The Swiss began to laugh boisterously. 'I go out?' he said. 'And why?'

'Ah, very well!' said D'Artagnan; 'I see that you understand French. Come then, and take a turn with me and I will explain.'

The hostess, who knew D'Artagnan's skill with the sword, began to weep and tear her hair. D'Artagnan turned toward her, saying, 'Then send him away, madame.'

'Pooh!' said the Swiss, who had needed a little time to take in D'Artagnan's proposal, 'pooh! who are you, in the first place, to ask me to take a turn with you?'

'I am lieutenant in his majesty's musketeers,' said D'Artagnan, 'and consequently your superior in everything; only, as the question now is not of rank, but of quarters—you know the custom—come and seek for yours; the first to return will recover his chamber.'

D'Artagnan led away the Swiss in spite of lamentations on the part of the hostess, who in reality found her heart inclining toward her former lover, though she would not have been sorry to give a lesson to that haughty musketeer who had affronted her by the refusal of her hand.

It was night when the two adversaries reached the field of battle. D'Artagnan politely begged the Swiss to yield to him the disputed chamber; the Swiss refused by shaking his head, and drew his sword.

'Then you will lie here,' said D'Artagnan. 'It is a wretched bed, but that is not my fault, and it is you who have chosen it.' With these words he drew in his turn and crossed swords with his adversary.

He had to contend against a strong wrist, but his agility was superior to all force. The Swiss received two wounds and was not aware of it, by reason of the cold; but suddenly feebleness, occasioned by loss of blood, obliged him to sit down.

road to salvation, I want you to tell me where he is, that he may help me to mine.'

'Rather say, to take him back with you into the world. Fortunately, I don't know where he is.'

'How!' cried D'Artagnan; 'you don't know where Aramis is?'

'Formerly,' replied Bazin, 'Aramis was his name of perdition. By Aramis is meant Simara, which is the name of a demon. Happily for him he has ceased to bear that name.'

'And therefore,' said D'Artagnan, resolved to be patient to the end, 'it is not Aramis I seek, but the Abbé d'Herblay. Come, my dear Bazin, tell me where he is.'

'Didn't you hear me tell you, Monsieur d'Artagnan, that I don't know where he is?'

'Yes, certainly; but to that I answer that it is impossible.'

'It is, nevertheless, the truth, monsieur—the pure truth, the truth of the good God.'

D'Artagnan saw clearly that he would get nothing out of this man, who was evidently telling a falsehood in his pretended ignorance of the abode of Aramis, but whose lies were bold and decided.

'Well, Bazin,' said D'Artagnan, 'since you do not know where your master lives, let us speak of it no more; let us part good friends. Accept this half-pistole to drink to my health.'

'I do not drink'—Bazin pushed away with dignity the officer's hand—''tis good only for the laity.'

'Incorruptible!' murmured D'Artagnan; 'I *am* unlucky;' and whilst he was lost in thought Bazin retreated toward the sacristy, and even there he could not think himself safe until he had shut and locked the door behind him.

D'Artagnan was still in deep thought when some one touched him on the shoulder. He turned and was about to utter an exclamation of surprise when the other made to him a sign of silence.

'You here, Rochefort?' he said, in a low voice.

'Hush!' returned Rochefort. 'Did you know that I am at liberty?'

'I knew it from the fountain-head—from Planchet. And what brought you here?'

'I came to thank God for my happy deliverance,' said Rochefort.

'And nothing more? I suppose that is not all.'

'To take my orders from the coadjutor and to see if we cannot wake up Mazarin a little.'

'A bad plan; you'll be shut up again in the Bastille.'

'Oh, as to that, I shall take care, I assure you. The air, the fresh, free air is so good; besides,' and Rochefort drew a deep breath as he spoke, 'I am going into the country to make a tour.'

'Stop,' cried D'Artagnan; 'I, too, am going.'

'And if I may without impertinence ask—where are you going?'

'To seek my friends.'

'What friends?'

'Those that you asked about yesterday.'

'Athos, Porthos and Aramis—you are looking for them?'

'Yes.'

'On honour?'

'What, then, is there surprising in that?'

'Nothing. Queer, though. And in whose behalf are you looking for them?'

'You are in no doubt on that score.'

'That is true.'

'Unfortunately, I have no idea where they are.'

'And you have no way to get news of them? Wait a week and I myself will give you some.'

'A week is too long. I must find them within three days.'

'Three days are a short time and France is large.'

'No matter; you know the word *must;* with that word great things are done.'

'And when do you set out?'

'I am now on my road.'

'Good luck to you.'

'And to you—a good journey.'

'Perhaps we shall meet on our road.'

'That is not probable.'

'Who knows? Chance is so capricious. Adieu, till we meet again! Apropos, should Mazarin speak to you about me, tell him that I should

'Who is that Swiss?' asked D'Artagnan

D'Artagnan looked out and at the corner of Rue Montmartre saw the hostess coming along hanging to the arm of an enormous Swiss, who tiptoed in his walk with a magnificent air which pleasantly reminded him of his old friend Porthos.

'Is that monsieur?' said D'Artagnan to himself. 'Oh! oh! he has grown a good deal, it seems to me.' And he sat down in the hall, choosing a conspicuous place.

The hostess, as she entered, saw D'Artagnan and uttered a little cry, whereupon D'Artagnan, judging that he had been recognised, rose, ran to her and embraced her tenderly. The Swiss, with an air of stupefaction, looked at the hostess, who turned pale.

'Ah, it is you, monsieur! What do you want of me?' she asked, in great distress.

'Is monsieur your cousin? Is monsieur your brother?' said D'Artagnan, not in the slightest degree embarrassed in the rôle he was playing. And without waiting for her reply he threw himself into the arms of the Helvetian, who received him with great coldness.

'Who is that man?' he asked.

The hostess replied only by gasps.

'Who is that Swiss?' asked D'Artagnan.

'Monsieur is going to marry me,' replied the hostess, between two gasps.

'Your husband, then, is at last dead?'

'How does that concern you?' replied the Swiss.

'It concerns me much,' said D'Artagnan, 'since you cannot marry madame without my consent and since— '

'And since?' asked the Swiss.

'And since—I do not give it,' said the musketeer.

The Swiss became as purple as a peony. He wore his elegant uniform, D'Artagnan was wrapped in a sort of gray cloak; the Swiss was six feet high, D'Artagnan was hardly more than five; the Swiss considered himself on his own ground and regarded D'Artagnan as an intruder.

'Will you go away from here?' demanded the Swiss, stamping violently, like a man who begins to be seriously angry.

'I? By no means!' said D'Artagnan.

have requested you to acquaint him that in a short time he will see whether I am, as he says, too old for action.'

And Rochefort went away with one of those diabolical smiles which used formerly to make D'Artagnan shudder, but D'Artagnan could now see it without alarm, and smiling in his turn, with an expression of melancholy which the recollections called up by that smile could, perhaps, alone give to his countenance, he said:

'Go, demon, do what thou wilt! It matters little now to me. There's no second Constance in the world.'

On his return to the cathedral, D'Artagnan saw Bazin, who was conversing with the sacristan. Bazin was making, with his spare little short arms, ridiculous gestures. D'Artagnan perceived that he was enforcing prudence with respect to himself.

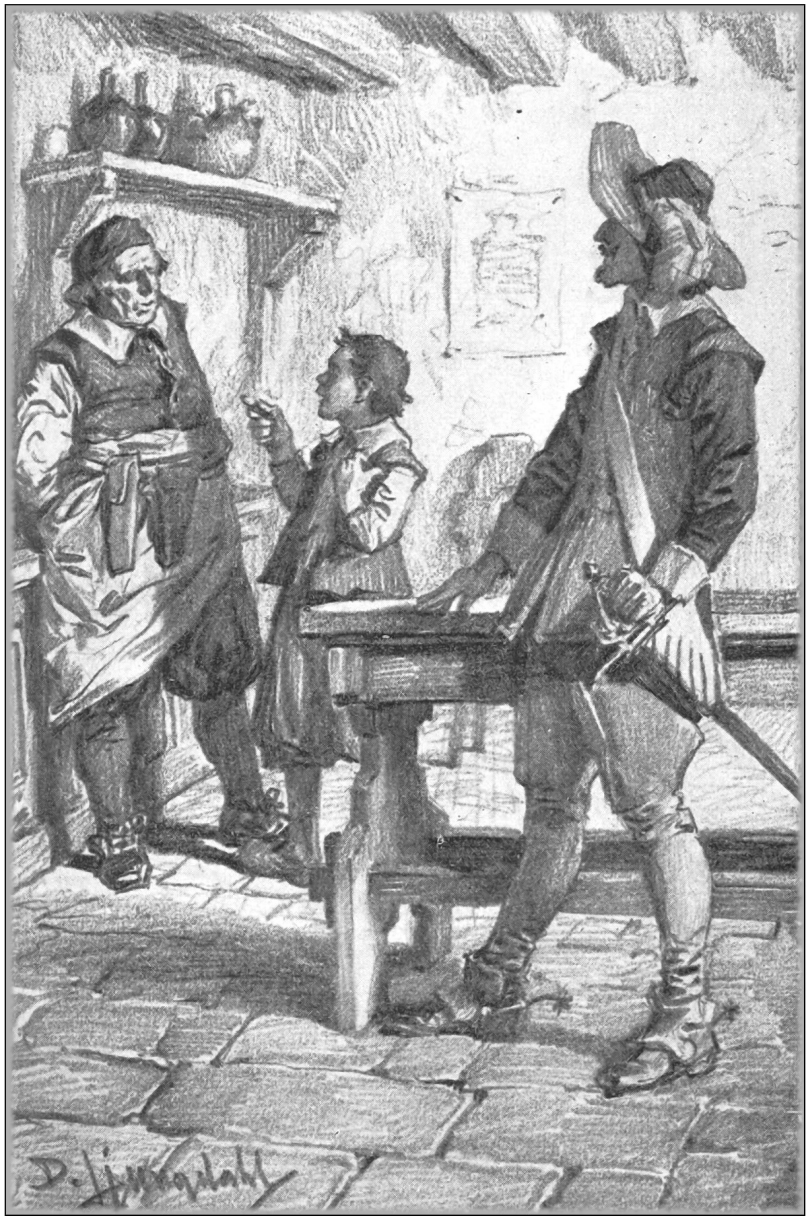
D'Artagnan slipped out of the cathedral and placed himself in ambuscade at the corner of the Rue des Canettes; it was impossible that Bazin should go out of the cathedral without his seeing him.

In five minutes Bazin made his appearance, looking in every direction to see if he were observed, but he saw no one. Calmed by appearances he ventured to walk on through the Rue Notre Dame. Then D'Artagnan rushed out of his hiding place and arrived in time to see Bazin turn down the Rue de la Juiverie and enter, in the Rue de la Calandre, a respectable looking house; and this D'Artagnan felt no doubt was the habitation of the worthy beadle. Afraid of making any inquiries at this house, D'Artagnan entered a small tavern at the corner of the street and asked for a cup of hypocras. This beverage required a good half-hour to prepare. And D'Artagnan had time, therefore, to watch Bazin unsuspected.

He perceived in the tavern a pert boy between twelve and fifteen years of age whom he fancied he had seen not twenty minutes before under the guise of a chorister. He questioned him, and as the boy had no interest in deceiving, D'Artagnan learned that he exercised, from six o'clock in the morning until nine, the office of chorister, and from nine o'clock till midnight that of a waiter in the tavern.

Whilst he was talking to this lad a horse was brought to the door of Bazin's house. It was saddled and bridled. Almost immediately Bazin came downstairs.

'Look!' said the boy, 'there's our beadle, who is going a journey.'



A PERT BOY BETWEEN TWELVE AND FIFTEEN

too grand to promise anything; he purposed only to do all that he could to increase the glory of his name.

As to that, we know D'Artagnan's courage; he exposed himself freely to danger and while charging at the head of his company he received a ball through the chest which laid him prostrate on the field of battle. He had been seen falling from his horse and had not been seen to rise; every one, therefore, believed him to be dead, especially those to whom his death would give promotion. One believes readily what he wishes to believe. Now in the army, from the division-generals who desire the death of the general-in-chief, to the soldiers who desire the death of the corporals, all desire some one's death.

But D'Artagnan was not a man to let himself be killed like that. After he had remained through the heat of the day unconscious on the battle-field, the cool freshness of the night brought him to himself. He gained a village, knocked at the door of the finest house and was received as the wounded are always and everywhere received in France. He was petted, tended, cured; and one fine morning, in better health than ever before, he set out for France. Once in France he turned his course toward Paris, and reaching Paris went straight to Rue Tiquetonne.

But D'Artagnan found in his chamber the personal equipment of a man, complete, except for the sword, arranged along the wall.

'He has returned,' said he. 'So much the worse, and so much the better!'

It need not be said that D'Artagnan was still thinking of the husband. He made inquiries and discovered that the servants were new and that the mistress had gone for a walk.

'Alone?' asked D'Artagnan.

'With monsieur.'

'Monsieur has returned, then?'

'Of course,' naïvely replied the servant.

'If I had any money,' said D'Artagnan to himself, 'I would go away; but I have none. I must stay and follow the advice of my hostess, while thwarting the conjugal designs of this inopportune apparition.'

He had just completed this monologue—which proves that in momentous circumstances nothing is more natural than the monologue—when the servant-maid, watching at the door, suddenly cried out:

'Ah! see! here is madame returning with monsieur.'